



REFRAMING NEGATIVE THOUGHTS | EXERCISE 3

Reframing Thoughts

Cognitive reframing challenges negative thoughts and replaces them with more positive and constructive thoughts. This helps you break free from limiting beliefs and re-trains your brain to think positively about situations and events.

The table below has some examples of negative thoughts and shows how these can be reframed into positive thoughts. Continue with positively reframing all the examples, it doesn't matter if your answers differ from the sample ones on the next sheet, this is a valuable lesson in seeing the positives in any situation and as you go through the list you will find it easier to positively reframe.

NEGATIVE THOUGHT	REFRAMED POSITIVE THOUGHT
I have never done it before	<i>It's a great opportunity to learn something new</i>
It's too complex	<i>I'll come at it from a different angle</i>
I don't have the resources	
My workload is too great	
I am the victim of the past	
We've always done it this way	
They have got it wrong	
The problem is.....	
Why did they get the promotion, it's unfair	
Too much to do, I don't know where to start	
I am tired of all these changes	
Putting my wellbeing first is selfish	
This won't work	
Why is this happening to me?	
I give up, I'll never be able to do this	
I never get anything right	
I made a mistake, I'm no good	



Reframing Thoughts

Example Answers:

NEGATIVE THOUGHT	REFRAMED POSITIVE THOUGHT
I have never done it before	<i>It's a great opportunity to learn something new</i>
It's too complex	<i>I'll come at it from a different angle</i>
I don't have the resources	<i>What would it take to make it happen?</i>
My workload is too great	<i>What can we prioritise?</i>
I am the victim of the past	<i>I can take control of my destiny</i>
We've always done it this way	<i>There may be a better way of doing things</i>
They have got it wrong	<i>Let me understand their point of view and offer some alternative ideas</i>
The problem is.....	<i>Here are some ideas to fix things</i>
Why did they get the promotion, it's unfair	<i>What can I do to make sure I am promoted next time round</i>
Too much to do, I don't know where to start	<i>Let's break the problem down and make a start</i>
I am tired of all these changes	<i>Let's explore what opportunities may come from these changes</i>
Putting my wellbeing first is selfish	<i>Self-care isn't selfish, it benefits everyone in the long term</i>
This won't work	<i>I will either make this work or consider some alternatives</i>
Why is this happening to me?	<i>What can I do differently, what can I learn from this?</i>
I give up, I'll never be able to do this	<i>This is really hard but I'm going to keep trying</i>
I never get anything right	<i>I haven't worked it out yet</i>
I made a mistake, I'm no good	<i>No-one is perfect</i>



REFRAMING NEGATIVE THOUGHTS

How to increase Positivity and Optimism - Best Practice



Avoid negative self-talk – after an event consider what you have learned and how you might apply that in the future rather than focusing on any negative aspects.



Challenge a negative thought – how accurate is it? Is it true to say that you 'never do anything right'?



Reframe the situation – look for ways to reframe an event in a more positive light.



Avoid jumping to conclusions: if a colleague appears distant or responds negatively towards you, rather than assuming it is something you did, consider what other outside influences may be impacting them.



Embrace challenges as opportunities for growth "I can't do this," becomes "I can't do this yet, but I'm learning."



Cultivate a growth mindset. Stimulating your brain with new skills/activities/learning can re-wire your brain, increase neural connections, positivity, and resilience.



Positive affirmations: "I can do this" "I've done this before and succeeded"



Re-direct your attention when re-living negative events/outcomes. Listen to music, walk, read a book.



Set realistic goals



Take time to savour and bank positive experiences into your long-term memory. Replay it several times in your memory and focus on how it made you feel.



Surround yourself with positive influences/people/support network: have lunch with positive colleagues and get their opinion on any ongoing challenges to get a different perspective.



Practice self-care: take care of your physical and mental wellbeing, including good nutrition, restorative sleep, and regular exercise.



Appreciate the small successes throughout the working day. Where you are involved in a major project, focus on the last few tasks you completed to give you a sense of achievement.



Cultivate positive thoughts, for example, rather than resenting time spent commuting, use it to learn a new skill or to review your ongoing tasks.



Make every situation a lesson learned: Review tasks or projects on completion: consider the challenges, what went well, and what you would do differently the next time to make the next project even more successful.



Use positive language in your workplace conversations to create a positive environment and make your team more optimistic about a project or deadline.



Express gratitude every day by reflecting on achievements, people, events, such as a successful presentation and make sure you thank people.



Find three positive aspects to every situation/challenge. For example, even though a team project is challenging positive aspects may be having the opportunity to work with the other team members or learn a new skill.



Participate in activities that reduce stress and boost mood such as socialising with friends, yoga, tai-chi, meditation, volunteering, physical challenges.



CBT (Cognitive Behavioural Therapy): identifies negative thoughts and challenges them with evidence.



Mindfulness & Meditation: Mindfulness involves being present in the moment and observing your thoughts without judgement and is a good way of breaking negative thought cycles.

Through the above strategies you can start to reshape your thought patterns and cultivate a more positive mindset to create a brain environment that's more positive and resilient.